

What is a backup and is it relevant to you?

If you own any sort of computing or digital device that hosts your data, a plan B is essential. Whether you're a student or a business owner, this is a critical need. Now that the term 'backup' has been thrown around aplenty let's get down to really understanding what the word means in this context. Put in the simplest of terms, taking a backup means generating a copy of any sort of data. The word 'copy' is of importance here and it must be clarified that the concepts of 'syncing' and 'backing up' are not synonymous with each other. A backup of any sort implies a data replication process. The data replicated may be stored in different media.

A data backup protects our content from a multitude of disasters. Our computers are hardly foolproof and are continually subject to some sort of hardware or software failure. Losing an important file due to a software crash may be disastrous if the file wasn't backed up. In case of a virus attack, most technicians will resort to a full system clean-up and again you may lose important data. Unlikely it may be, but our systems face the pervasive threat of natural disasters or power outages, which mete out damage to various machines. All these problems are avoidable with a disaster recovery plan. Who knows, somewhere down the line, you may thank Digit for saving your precious data should a voltage spike damage your laptop (God forbid!). A backup even ensures protection against the stupidest of occurrences such as accidental deletions. Long story short, you spend a major part of your life in the virtual space, generating large amounts of data. And if you don't, you will soon. The world is shifting to the digital space. Heck, even our very own Modi Sarkar is a proponent of e-Governance. In the wake of this revolution, it's very important to back up your data.

Cautionary tales

In a recently conducted study, 90 per cent of people don't back up their data. Another study by National Archives & Records Administration (NARA) found that 93 per cent of companies that lost their data centres for 10 days or more due to a disaster went bankrupt within a year. During Hurricane Sandy in the US, many companies based in lower Manhattan went offline and incurred avoidable data losses. Many companies don't seem to employ any backup methods, including downright simplistic online backups. It should be pointed out that most of these studies are carried out by data recovery companies and should be taken with a pinch of salt.